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Y.S. Sharmila with Rahul Gandhi and Congress president Mallikarjun Kharge, Jan. 4

On

January 4, even as All India Congress Committee president Mallikarjun Kharge welcomed Y.S. Sharmila, daughter of the late Y.S. Rajasekhara Reddy (YSR), the former chief minister of united Andhra Pradesh, into the Congress with a shawl in the party's tricolours, her brother and current CM, Y.S. Jagan Mohan Reddy of the YSR Congress Party (YSRCP), was in Hyderabad spending two hours with the convalescing K. Chandrashekar Rao (KCR)—whose Bharat Rashtra Samithi had just lost the mandate in contiguous Telangana—and perhaps learning from their failure amid new challenges.

Sibling rivalry now threatens to tear asunder YSR's political legacy that Jagan had reclaimed after years of tumultuous struggle. YSR's tragic death in a helicopter crash in September 2009, shortly after he led the Congress to a second consecutive assembly election win, had led to a parting of ways with the family. Jagan floated his own political formation in 2011, taking away some of the Congress base. Then came the reorganisation of the state itself in 2014, and the birth of Telangana. The Grand Old Party hit rock bottom when it failed to win a single seat and only 2.4 per cent of the vote share in the 2014 election (presumably because the voters blamed it for the bifurcation), which slipped even further to 1.2 per cent in 2019 (less than the number of votes polled for NOTA).

Beginning last year, a glimmer of hope has arisen for the Congress in South India, first with a victory in Karnataka, followed by one in Telangana, where the Congress managed to trump the two-term government of KCR. The party now fancies its chances in Andhra Pradesh and is hoping to wrest back the legacy that YSR had left behind, via his daughter. Sharmila's entry is expected to not just shape her own political future but her absence is also expected to have implications for the YSRCP, for which she has been campaigning for a decade. The Congress itself is buoyant about her leadership spearheading a revival. In fact, to celebrate the 'homecoming', the party plans to hold meetings of mandal and zilla parishad leaders this month. "The mood is buoyant," says Congress Working Committee member N. Raghuveera Reddy, who was the state party chief at the time of the 2014 rout. "What seemed like a Herculean task till a few months ago, seems doable now. The air is conducive and we are talking to YSRCP leaders who are looking to switch."

Despite his outward nonchalance, Jagan may need to worry. Already, many YSRCP leaders, apprehensive about not getting party tickets, are drifting Congressward. And even in the YSRCP, Jagan can't escape the Congress gene—18 of his 25 ministers are ex-Congressmen. He has now named 38 new coordinators for the assembly and Lok Sabha polls.